

Open Source Firewalls: The Best in the Business



Firewalls form a vital part of the network security system, isolating the network from all kinds of intrusions. This article discusses some open source firewalls that the author believes are the best available.

A firewall is the most important part of a network security system. It acts like a wall between internal and external networks. The main purpose of a firewall is to stop intruders like viruses, Trojan attackers and hackers. It keeps monitoring the incoming and outgoing network traffic to block any kind of cracking, snooping, DDo attacks, etc. Firewalls come in two forms — hardware and software firewalls. Today we will discuss software firewalls that are free and open source.

There are dozens of open source firewalls available online to download under open source licences but out of them, I would like to recommend pfSense (FreeBSD) and ClearOS. This article features a few other noteworthy firewalls too.

1. pfSense

pfSense is an open source security solution with a custom kernel based on the FreeBSD OS. It is a software distribution that is customised especially to be used as a firewall and router. This open source firewall can be installed on bare metal hardware and be managed entirely through a Web

interface. Apart from firewalling and routing platforms, you can expand its functionality by using its many features, without adding bloat and potential security vulnerabilities to the base distribution.

Features

- Firewall – IP/port filtering, limiting connections, Layer 2 capable, scrubbing
- State table – By default, all rules are stateful, and there are multiple configurations available for state handling
- Server load balancing (LB) – Inbuilt LB to distribute load between multiple backend servers
- NAT (network address translation) – Port forwarding, reflection
- HA (high-availability) – Failover to secondary if primary fails
- Multi-WAN (wide area network) – Uses more than one Internet connection
- VPN (virtual private network) – Supports IPsec and OpenVPN